

Extra Credit

ANTH-202 | Archaeology: Our Human Past

Instructor: Tracie Mayfield

Term: Fall 2026

Assignment Summary

Grade weight: Not graded / optional

Due date: 2026-12-08

Group project: No

Extra Credit Assignment

assignment...see the EXTRA CREDIT SECTION below. • If you have a situation come up that will require that you miss more than 9 classes -which would equal missing 3 weeks of classes, I urge you to get ahold of your advisor about dropping the course or taking an incomplete and finishing up during an upcoming semester; you simply cannot do well in the course if you cannot come to class for whatever reason that may be. IMPORTANT! Please read... For lecture sessions (Tu/Th 2pm-3:20pm) you will use QWICKLY (via Brightspace) to log in within the first 3 minutes of class. Please make sure to have a device with you in class that will allow you to sign in. For lab/discussion sections, I will call roll at the beginning of class. Arriving on time for classes is important to the flow of the class and it is required. Clearly, sometime things happen and you might arrive late, but chronic lateness is unacceptable. To this end, every 3 late arrivals will result in a 2-point deduction to your overall participation grade. No exceptions. • LAB SECTIONS (Tuesdays): • You must have completed all the assignments in the WEEKLY INSTRUCTION MODULE prior to attending your lab section, but you do not need to turn in anything in prior to class, unless otherwise noted...just show up and be able to do the exercises and have the discussions outlined in the WEEKLY MODULE INSTRUCTIONS. • During lab sections, we will: § Have a short lecture on the week's themes and assigned materials and watch some short films. § Do an experiential exercise and/or have a discussion about the current week's materials and themes. 5 -- 5 of 16 -- • LECTURE SESSIONS (Tuesdays & Thursdays): • During lecture sessions, we will: • Have short lectures on the week's themes and assigned materials, and watch some short films. • Have 'open' time (most weeks) where you can work on your case study or the upcoming weeks' assignments...such as viewing films, reading, answering content study questions from the weekly module instructions, preparing for lab section exercises & discussions either on your own or with other students, taking the weekly quiz (which you can do with other students!)...and get help from the instructor with course content or your analytical case study (final paper). • While lab sections are highly structured, lecture sessions are generally less so - other than the short lectures, which 1) allows for students to get real-time, individualized help from the instructor, 2) provides a space for students to work on their own to complete weekly assignments, 3) presents opportunities for students to work on the course materials and their research projects with each other...students can even complete the weekly quizzes together! 2) 2% Attend the USC Archaeology Center Field Trip - As part of the course assignments, students are required to attend the USC Archaeology Center during their regularly scheduled lab/discussion section on November 3. Students who are unable to attend may instead complete the extra credit assignment described in this syllabus (below) as an alternative to the field trip. 3) 8% Weekly Quizzes - find on Brightspace under ACTIVITIES>QUIZZES and complete by 7:00pm on Fridays of the current week, unless otherwise noted in

the COURSE SCHEDULE (see below). Quizzes are posted at least week in advance. • You can take the quiz as many times as you like before the deadline to get the grade you want/need. • PRO TIP!! Take the quiz before you do the weekly readings and other preparatory work so you know what to look for...then take it again after you complete your weekly assignments to improve your grade if need be. • You can work collaboratively with other students on the quizzes...e.g. during lecture sessions. • While you could just get the answers from another student, the point of the quizzes is to make sure you have the information you need to do well on the exams. The multiple-choice and true/false sections of the exams will come straight from the quizzes, so the better you actua

Full Syllabus Extract

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dropped for the final weekly-quiz grade average calculation. • No make-up quizzes will be available because the answers to the quizzes will be posted after the due date/time (in the CONTENT section of BRIGHTSPACE as PDF documents) for you to access to prepare for exams. If you miss more than three quizzes, you can do the extra credit assignment to make up any lost points. 4) 40% Midterm & Final Exams [20% each] (online, via Brightspace under ACTIVITIES>QUIZZES) - More information will be sent out about the exams during the semester. • Exams will be online (open book and open notes) and the final exam is NOT CUMULATIVE. • NOTE: OSAS students will automatically have their extra time added to the first part of the exam (if your paperwork has been submitted to the instructor at least two weeks before the exam). • All rules regarding plagiarism and AI use apply to the exam essay questions. See the sections on 'Plagiarism' & 'AI Use' below for more information. • NOTE: While studying together for the exam is encouraged, it is expected that you take the exams on your own. While the exams are open, you should not discuss the exam with anyone, seek answers from other students while taking the exam, or ask other students who have already taken the exam questions about the exam. • You CAN use your notes, any of the course materials, and even look up information online; but you will need to refrain from logging onto chat/discussion/messaging apps while the exam periods are open. • If you share information with other students or seek out answers to questions from other students (this includes being on chat and 'passively' getting information about the exam) while the exam window is open, you will receive a 0 on the exam. • MIDTERM EXAM (1 hour & 20 minutes) - see the course schedule below for date/time • 20-25 multiple choice & true/false questions • Utilize the weekly quizzes (most of the questions will come directly from the weekly quizzes), lectures, readings, & films, and study questions (in the WEEKLY MODULE INSTRUCTIONS) to prepare for this section of the exam. • 2 essay questions • Utilize the lab section exercises & discussions, lectures, readings, & films, and study questions (in the WEEKLY MODULE INSTRUCTIONS) to prepare for this section of the exam. • Suggested length that an average student needs to properly answer a short essay is approximately 500-800 words PER ESSAY QUESTION, but note that credit is based on content quality, use of professional language (specific to anthropology & archaeology), readability, having specific connections to the course materials [readings, films, lectures, discussions, etc.], and completeness & cogency, not word count. • From your answers, I want to be confident that you have been completing the assignments and have been through all of the course materials...show me that you have taken this course, in particular. It will be clear if you have not been keeping up with the course materials and/or not participating in lab sections. 6

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• Because generative AI can readily produce large amounts of information, simply providing more content does not demonstrate learning. High-quality exam responses synthesize relevant evidence rather than compiling it. Students should focus on answering the question directly by integrating course concepts, examples, and terminology into a coherent argument that demonstrates an understanding of how the material fits together, rather than presenting disconnected facts or exhaustive summaries. • SEE ALSO THE AI USE INFORMATION BELOW, which is important for how I grade everything in this course. • FINAL EXAM (2 hours) - see the course schedule below for date/time • 15-20 multiple choice & true/false questions • Utilize the weekly quizzes (most of the questions will come directly from the weekly quizzes), lectures, readings, & films, and study questions (in the WEEKLY MODULE INSTRUCTIONS) to prepare for this section of the exam. • 3 essay questions • Utilize the lab section exercises & discussions, lectures, readings, & films, and study questions (in the WEEKLY MODULE INSTRUCTIONS) to prepare for this section of the exam. • Suggested length that an average student needs to properly answer a short essay is approximately 500-800 words PER ESSAY QUESTION, but note that credit is based on content quality, use of professional language (specific to anthropology & archaeology), readability, having specific connections to the course materials [readings, films, lectures, discussions, etc.], and completeness & cogency, not word count. • From your answers, I want to be confident that you have been completing the assignments and have been through all of the course materials...show me that you have taken this course, in particular. It will be clear if you have not been keeping up with the course materials and/or not participating in lab sections. • Because generative AI can readily produce large amounts of information, simply providing more content does not demonstrate learning. High-quality exam responses synthesize relevant evidence rather than compiling it. Students should focus on answering the question directly by integrating course concepts, examples, and terminology into a coherent argument that demonstrates an understanding of how the material fits together, rather than presenting disconnected facts or exhaustive summaries. • SEE ALSO THE AI USE INFORMATION BELOW, which is

important for how I grade everything in this course. 5) 35% Analytical Case-Study (2 research design worksheets + 2 peer-review exercises + 1 final paper) - see the 'final paper instructions' for more detailed information; and find the 'research design' & 'peer-review' worksheet templates on Brightspace under CONTENT & see the course schedule below for due dates. More information to come during the semester about analytical case studies, research designs, and peer-reviews. • 1% = completion/submission of the Research Design Worksheet 1 (TOPIC) (submit via Brightspace>ACTIVITIES) • 2% = completion of the Discussion Board Peer-Review workshop 1 (TOPIC) 1. Make sure you have posted YOUR RESEARCH DESIGN WORKSHEET #1 VERBIAGE to the DISCUSSION BOARD (under ACTIVITIES in the proper thread), which SHOULD HAVE ALREADY BEEN COMPLETED per the Research Design Worksheet #1 instructions. 2. COMMENT ON 3 OTHER STUDENT'S WORKSHEET 1 VERBIAGE THREADS on the DISCUSSION BOARD (under ACTIVITIES) using the questions provided in the 'peer-review 1' worksheet (TEMPLATE under CONTENT). 3. SUBMIT A STUDENT COMMENT LIST (the document should include the name of each student you reviewed, along with your comments). • Submit under ACTIVITIES>ASSIGNMENTS on Brightspace. • ALL 3 parts must be completed to receive credit for the workshop. No exceptions. • 1% = completion/submission of the Research Design Worksheet 2 (OPENING PARAGRAPH & BIBLIOGRAPHY) (submit via Brightspace>ACTIVITIES) • 2% = completion of the Discussion Board Peer-Review workshop 2 (OPENING PARAGRAPH & BIBLIOGRAPHY) 1. Make sure you have posted YOUR RESEARCH DESIGN WORKSHEET #2 VERBIAGE to the DISCUSSION BOARD (under ACTIVITIES in the proper thread), which SHOULD HAVE ALREADY BEEN COMPLETED per the Research Design Worksheet #2 instructions. 2. COMMENT ON 3 OTHER STUDENT'S WORKSHEET 2 VERBIAGE THREADS on the DISCUSSION BOARD (under ACTIVITIES) using the questions provided in the 'peer-review 2' worksheet (TEMPLATE under CONTENT). 3. SUBMIT A STUDENT COMMENT LIST (the document should include the name of each student you reviewed, along with your comments). • Submit under ACTIVITIES>ASSIGNMENTS on Brightspace. • ALL 3 parts must be completed to receive credit for the workshop. No exceptions. • 29% = final paper submission (submit via BRIGHTSPACE>ACTIVITIES) • You can petition for an extension on your final paper, by completing the protocol outlined below in the LATE SUBMISSION POLICY SECTION before the posted due date, but note that ALL COURSE ASSIGNMENTS, including your final paper must be submitted by 11:59pm on the last day of study days before exams begin to receive credit. • NOTE: The instructor will not look over whole drafts for commenting, but will look over specific sections, if you have specific questions. Make sure to get your draft sections in for comment early because the queue for comments becomes longer the closer we get to the deadline. To this end, you may or may not get comments back before the deadline if your draft section is sent less than a week before the due date/time. Continue working on your assignment and do not wait on a response to complete and submit your work. 7

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AI USE Within this class, you are welcome to use AI. However, you should note that all large language models have a tendency to make up incorrect facts and fake citations, data modeling tends to produce inaccurate outputs, and image generation is usually almost completely (and many times offensively) wrong. In this course, you are fully responsible for the accuracy of all content you submit, including factual claims, interpretations, and representations of evidence, regardless of whether the material was written by you or generated with the assistance of an AI tool or other external source. Fabrication, falsification, or distortion of evidence violates USC's definitions of academic dishonesty, whether produced manually or via AI tools. AI tools are an expected and legitimate part of the research and writing process in this course. However, they must be used as partners in thinking and drafting, not as producers of your work. AI can help summarize, organize, or clarify information, but it cannot replace your analytical labor, interpretive judgment, or engagement with course materials. For exam essays and case study assignments (including the final paper), I am not looking for summaries. I am looking for evidence of nuanced understanding, demonstrated through your ability to work across multiple types of data, evaluate their relationships, and explain how and why those data matter. Strong work shows synthesis, comparison, and interpretation...not surface-level restatement. Because generative AI can readily produce large amounts of information, simply providing more content does not demonstrate learning. High-quality work synthesizes relevant evidence rather than compiling it. You should focus on integrating course concepts, examples, and terminology into coherent analyses that demonstrate an understanding of how the material fits together, rather than presenting disconnected facts or exhaustive summaries. This level of analysis can only come from sustained engagement with the course: completing the readings, watching and reflecting on course materials, participating in

discussion, and thoughtfully working through the study questions. In short, meaningful scholarship requires real human intellectual labor, not automated output. AI may support that process, but it cannot replace it. This means you should engage with AI tools to brainstorm, do spelling and grammar checks, refine, clarify, or explore ideas, but the final product must clearly reflect your own holistic and nuanced thinking, voice, and judgment. Your work should demonstrate clear, original analysis; strong research; coherent writing; minimal grammar issues; authentic understanding of your topic; and avoid AI-style vagueness, repetition, superficiality, and fabricated details. I will be looking for holistic & research informed thinking, well-structured organization, detailed and varied evidence and data sources, personal voice, and human judgment throughout; and considering the help AI can provide, your work must be extremely well written, free of spelling and grammatical errors, and follow all formatting and prompt instructions. AI-generated content often lacks specificity, substitutes clichés for insight, and fabricates sources or examples. In contrast, human writing demonstrates nuance, context awareness, meaningful synthesis, and intentional structure. These are not only academic expectations, but they are also professional and transferable skills you will need in any discipline or industry moving forward. In addition, your work should clearly show active participation and engagement with the specific themes, methodologies, and theoretical foundations we have explored in this course. Your writing should reflect that you have taken this particular course; AI cannot replicate that level of engagement or familiarity with our shared discussions, readings, and exercises. I have been using AI extensively for many years now and can easily recognize work that has not been properly vetted or authored by a human. Submissions that over-rely on AI (without thoughtful engagement, editing, and human input) will lose points for failing to meet expectations of depth, accuracy, cogency, and professionalism. AI-generated or heavily AI-assisted writing is often identifiable through the following patterns: • Lack of contextual specificity: Writing relies on broad or abstract statements about "archaeology," "the past," or "human behavior" without grounding claims in concrete data, clearly defined case studies, time periods, geographic locations, or material evidence. • Generic or formulaic phrasing: Language sounds polished but interchangeable, using predictable academic constructions that could apply to many topics without demonstrating focused engagement with the particular materials, readings, or examples addressed in the course. • Absence of analytical positioning: The response summarizes concepts without showing how the writer is thinking through the evidence; there is little indication of uncertainty, interpretation, tradeoffs, or decision-making that characterize real archaeological analysis. • Detachment from empirical evidence: Claims are not clearly supported by specific artifacts, features, datasets, figures, or assigned sources, or they include inaccuracies that suggest the material was synthesized rather than examined closely. To this end, AI tools may be used only for limited support tasks (such as brainstorming, outlining, or proofreading for clarity). They may not be used to generate substantive content, including descriptions, observations, interpretations, arguments, or comparisons. Archaeological writing requires engagement with specific data, case studies, and contexts that must come from your own analysis or points will be deducted, whether the disengagement comes from a lack of participation or overuse of AI...both read the same. Effective archaeological writing should read as situated, data-driven, and interpretive, demonstrating that arguments emerge from direct engagement with archaeological evidence and course materials, not from generalized summaries or automated synthesis. 8

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EXTRA CREDIT2 • The following assignment is worth up to 3 extra credit COURSE POINTS (so, up to +3 course points for a 90% or higher grade on your extra credit submission added to your final grade, which will bump you a whole letter grade; e.g. A- to an A), and can be turned in any time during the semester until 11:59pm on the last day of study days (see the COURSE SCHEDULE for the exact date). § Submit the extra credit assignment via the Brightspace ACTIVITIES>ASSIGNMENTS section (use the proper folder) by the deadline. § Follow all the directions; complete all the prompts AND use the correct format...or you will lose points. § Make sure to look over the PLAGIARISM and AI USE sections of the syllabus. **Museums, Materiality, and Meaning: A Comparative Analysis of Three NHM Exhibitions Overview** For this extra-credit assignment, you will engage directly with three Natural History Museum exhibitions (two in-person and one online) and produce a single, integrated comparative, reflexive analysis. This assignment is designed to assess your ability to critically evaluate material culture, exhibition design, and interpretive narratives, while explicitly connecting museum practice to the themes and frameworks of this course. You should compare, contrast, and critically reflect across all three exhibitions, drawing on your own embodied experience as a visitor to these exhibits and as an archaeology student in this course. Exhibitions (you must visit all three): 1. Visible Vault - Natural History Museum (in

person) 2. *Becoming Los Angeles* - Natural History Museum (in person) 3. *The Fabric of Community: Tapa and Woven Mats from the Pacific Islands* - NHM online exhibition

<https://nhm.org/experience-nhm/exhibitions-natural-history-museum/fabric-community> Requirements • Format: o Your paper should be written as a single, cohesive essay that compares and contrasts all three exhibits, utilizing the following (required) sections below, in the order in which they are presented. § You must address all of the prompts below for your paper to fully meet the expectations of this exercise. o Your paper should be at least 1,200 words. § List the word count at the top of your document. o You must include at least 1 photo of yourself at each in-person exhibit. o Turn in the assignment no later than the final due date and time (see the COURSE SCHEDULE for the exact date). No exceptions. • Output Expectations Overview: o Your response should show an appropriate level of depth, clarity, engagement, and analytical precision for the course. Your response should demonstrate meaningful engagement with the course materials and the museum exhibits; offering interpretations and connections that reflect thoughtful consideration. o Each sentence should contribute new information, add to the depth and breadth of the analysis, and presents specific examples that advance the response rather than repeating previously stated content, just in different ways. Answers that are technically accurate but limited in scope, development, or analytic contribution do not fully meet the expectations of this prompt. • SECTIONS (required): 1. *Types of Exhibition Materials, Presentation of Materials, and the Visitor Experience** • Briefly describe each exhibit's organization; how is it set up for the visitor to move through the exhibit? • Identify the types of materials featured in each exhibit (objects, specimens, textiles, archival documents, digital media, etc.). • Compare how material culture is used/presented differently (or similarly!) across the three exhibits. § Examples may include, but are not limited to: § How does physical proximity to objects (in the in-person exhibits) shape interpretation compared to the online exhibit? § Does the layout or lighting shape the experience? How so? § Is the layout in chronological order? ...if not, how is it organized to move through? • Identify at least one limitation or problem in each exhibition. § These may include issues of representation, accessibility, narrative framing, omissions, layout, lighting, signage, etc. § Compare how these issues manifest differently across physical and digital exhibition spaces. 2 See the FAQ section of the syllabus...doing the extra credit assignment is linked to my final grade bumping policies. 9

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• In your opinion, which exhibitions most successfully communicate meaning through material evidence, and why? *This section should clearly reflect your personal experience as a visitor and should not be a generalized commentary. 2. Learning Outcomes & Knowledge Production • What did you learn from each exhibition that you did not already know? Be specific... 3. Course Connections* • Address the following questions, and make sure to make explicit connections between the concepts, case studies, reading/film materials, or discussions from this course and the museum exhibits: § How did the objects, specimens, or materials on display function as archaeological evidence rather than simply as "museum objects"? § Where did you notice the limits of material evidence; in other words...what questions could the objects help answer, and what questions remain unresolved? § Explain how the exhibitions illustrate the kinds of interpretive choices archaeologists must make when working with partial, incomplete, or curated material records. Be specific. § Examples might include (but are not limited to): • Understanding the lived experiences of people in the past • Understanding how cultures change over time • Material vs. documentary data • Representation and voice • Heritage and authenticity • Museums as sites of authenticity and cultural interpretation *Vague references to "things we talked about in class" or "the stuff in the exhibit" will not receive full credit, you need to be specific.